

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Legislation to protect warehouse workers

The bill comes amid complaints that demands for speed hinder safety

By Addison Wright
Chicago Tribune

Legislation now on Gov. JB Pritzker's desk aims at providing protections for workers at large warehouses such as those run by Amazon by requiring employers to be more transparent about productivity expectations and ensure workloads don't prevent employees from taking breaks for meals, rest or visits to the bathroom.

The measure, passed by state lawmakers earlier this month, is in response to reports that warehouse workers are too often pushed beyond their physical limits. In December, Amazon reached a \$145,000 settlement with the U.S. Occupational Safety and Health Administration over accusations that conditions at an Illinois warehouse left workers exposed to elevated risks of injury.

If Pritzker signs the bill into law, Illinois would join five other states that have similar measures on the books and dozens of others that have introduced legislation attempting to address warehouse workplace issues.

The bill covers warehouses that employ 250 or more workers at a single warehouse distribution center, or 1,000 or more employees at such facilities statewide. State Rep. Kevin Olickal, a Chicago Democrat who sponsored the bill, said warehousing is one of the fastest growing industries in the country and the measure "specifically addresses some of those concerns we're finding in those warehouse spaces."

"The bill is really just trying to address some of the working conditions and the efficiency standards and quotas that are used in warehouses like Amazon," Olickal said.

Between 2021 and 2022, Amazon warehouse workers across Illinois were injured at a rate of 8.2 per 100, which was 30%

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A family picks up their child at Two Rivers Head Start Agency on Sullivan Road in Aurora on Tuesday. Earlier in the day, President Donald Trump's administration announced a freeze on federal grants, which could affect Illinois Head Start programs. A federal judge temporarily blocked the freeze. Two Rivers is among programs that would be in danger of shutting down without the necessary federal funding. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Federal funding freeze sows panic before block

Trump administration's effort to pause grants would impact Medicaid, state agencies

By Olivia Olander, Alice Yin, Lisa Schencker, Sarah Freishtat and Robert McCoppin
Chicago Tribune

A federal judge temporarily blocked a Trump administration effort to freeze federal grants and potentially trillions of dollars in spending, but not before the Republican president's declaration caused widespread tumult and confusion within Illinois government and among social service agencies, nonprofits and universities.

The decision late Tuesday

afternoon by U.S. District Judge Loren AliKhan in Washington, D.C., came as Democratic leaders across the country, including in Illinois, vowed to fight the spending pause, which they viewed as unconstitutional.

AliKhan blocked the action minutes before it was set to go into effect at 4 p.m. The administrative stay pauses the freeze until Monday.

The judge's decision capped a day filled with confusion, anger, frustration and fear across the nation after President Donald Trump's Office of Management and Budget called for the tempo-

INSIDE: President Donald Trump's move on loans, grants sets up a constitutional clash.
Nation & World

rary pause on funding, including for programs related to "foreign aid, nongovernmental organizations, DEI (diversity, equity and inclusion programs), woke gender ideology, and the green new deal," which was a sweeping environment-friendly initiative to combat climate change.

But among the most immediate impacts appeared to be the Medicaid system, a state and

federally funded health insurance program for people with low incomes and disabilities.

Illinois state agencies reported Tuesday morning that state employees were unable to access Medicaid payment systems, a top spokesman for Gov. JB Pritzker said. The system came back online for Illinois later in the day.

"Our state agencies were unable to access the Medicaid system until an hour ago, preventing payments for services," Pritzker said at a news conference late Tuesday. "This has been

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MICHAEL MADIGAN TRIAL



Former lobbyist Michael McClain places a hand on attorney Patrick Cotter's shoulder as they exit the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse on Tuesday. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Spotlight turns to co-defendant McClain

Friend, confidant and lobbyist 'thought he was doing his job'

By Jason Meisner, Megan Crepeau and Ray Long
Chicago Tribune

For nearly four months, the marquee name in Courtroom 1203 of Chicago's federal courthouse has been ex-Speaker Michael Madigan, the former Illinois political powerhouse now on trial for public corruption.

But on Tuesday, the spotlight

was entirely on his lesser-known co-defendant, Michael McClain, a retired lobbyist who for decades was a member of Madigan's small inner circle.

McClain was a diligent — if sometimes "blunt" and "earthy" — lobbyist who never agreed to or knew about any bribery scheme, his attorney Patrick Cotter told jurors in closing arguments Tuesday. He only ever acted out of a commitment to his clients and a true respect for Madigan, Cotter said.

"Did this very real, very unique and — I would submit based on

the overall evidence in this case — very decent human being actually have the intent to engage in a conspiracy to bribe the person he thought of as his closest friend?" Cotter asked.

Closing arguments began last week and have already lasted about 23 hours, far longer than typical even for a complex trial. U.S. District Judge John Robert Blakey declined to put time limits on closings, and Cotter's argument took more than 4 1/2 hours Tuesday. Prosecutors argued for

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Netanyahu set for White House visit

Meeting next week would be a first for Trump's new term

By Wafaa Shurafa and Melanie Lidman
Associated Press

WADI GAZA, Gaza Strip — President Donald Trump has invited Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu to the White House on Feb. 4 as the first foreign leader to visit in Trump's second term, Netanyahu and the White House said Tuesday.

The announcement came as the United States pressures Israel and Hamas to continue a ceasefire that has paused a devastat-

ing 15-month war in Gaza. Talks about the ceasefire's more difficult second phase, which aims to end the war, are set to begin Feb. 3.

The White House letter shared by Netanyahu's office, dated Tuesday, said "I look forward to discussing how we can bring peace to Israel and its neighbors, and efforts to counter our shared adversaries."

The meeting would be a chance for Netanyahu, under pressure at home, to remind the world of the support he has received from Trump over the years, and to defend Israel's conduct of the war. Last year, the

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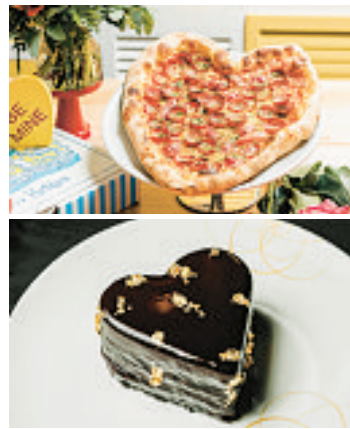
INSIDE

Served with love for Valentine's Day

70 specials at Chicagoland restaurants and bars, from romantic dinners to Galentine's Day gatherings. **Food & Health**

Competing in age of 'super franchises'

The Cubs couldn't compete with the Dodgers in the offseason. Why would it be different on the field? **Paul Sullivan in Chicago Sports**



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